

LATE BIBLICAL HEBREW AND HEBREW INSCRIPTIONS*

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1. *The Hebrew Inscriptions in Recent Debate*

The corpus of Hebrew inscriptions from the biblical period¹ has recently had a pivotal role in discussions of the history of the Hebrew language and its relevance for the origins of the Bible. The linguistic evidence has been used to argue against attempts to date the origin of all the biblical literature in the Persian or later eras (e.g. by P.R. Davies 1992). Two of the most authoritative statements of this position are by Avi Hurvitz and Martin Ehrensverd (Hurvitz 1997a; 1999; 2000a; 2001; Ehrensverd 1997).² I will first of all investigate the role which these scholars ascribe to the Hebrew inscriptions in their discussions. I shall then re-examine these claims in the light of the Hebrew inscriptional corpus.

Hurvitz emphasises that 'non-biblical sources...provide us with the external control required in any attempt to detect and identify diachronic developments within BH' (Hurvitz 1997a: 307). He concludes 'that, by and large, there is a far-reaching linguistic uniformity underlying both the pre-exilic inscriptions and the literary biblical texts written in Classical BH' (p. 308). 'We have, therefore, to conclude that "Classical BH" is a well-defined linguistic statum, indicative of a (typologically) datable time-span within biblical literature and a (chronologically) datable time-span

within biblical history' (p. 309). The chronological distinction between a pre-exilic 'CBH' and a post-exilic 'LBH'

is based, by and large, on two important corpora of extra-biblical sources... on the one hand, the Dead Sea Scrolls—dated to the end of the biblical period—which betray numerous isoglosses specifically with Late BH; and on the other hand, an increasing number of Hebrew epigraphical inscriptions—dated to the pre-exilic period—which largely conform to the linguistic profile of Classical BH. (Hurvitz 1999: 30*)³

Ehrensverd also stresses the importance of the extra-biblical linguistic evidence. He is aware that, for example, 'One could argue that the differences [within BH] are simply due to differences in the proficiency of Standard Biblical Hebrew of two groups of contemporary writers' (Ehrensverd 1997: 36). However, the extra-biblical evidence

strongly suggests a difference in time between the language of the two groups [SBH and LBH]; the linguistic features proper to LBH are not found in the (admittedly rather limited corpus of) pre-exilic inscriptions, but by and large they are prevalent in post-Biblical Hebrew. In the pre-exilic inscriptions...there *are* found, on the contrary, distinctive features indicative of SBH. (Hurvitz 1999: 36-37)

The main points raised by Hurvitz and Ehrensverd are the following. The CBH or SBH of, say, Genesis–2 Kings is practically identical with the Hebrew of the inscriptions from the monarchic period. That, they say, establishes the pre-exilic date of composition of those biblical books. In contrast, the LBH of, say, Chronicles, has definite links with late sources such as the Dead Sea Scrolls. There are linguistic features found in the early inscriptions which are not found in LBH sources. Nor are distinctively LBH features found in the inscriptions. The extra-biblical sources establish that SBH is contemporary with the Hebrew inscriptions of the

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1. The corpus has been presented most recently in Renz and Röhlrig 1995 and Gogel 1998. When naming the inscriptions I have generally followed Gogel's simplified system. I also refer to the texts published by Beit-Arieh (1993), Deutsch and Heltzer (1994; 1995), and Naveh (2000). Schüle (2000) is a recent comprehensive linguistic analysis.

2. For Ehrensverd's revised position see his article above.

3. Hurvitz often also includes 'the Canaanite inscriptions of the first half of the first millennium B.C.E.', as well as Ugaritic evidence (Hurvitz 1997a: 308 n. 18) alongside Hebrew epigraphical evidence (see, e.g., Hurvitz 1982: 80 n. 82). However he stresses that it is strictly the Hebrew evidence that is of greatest importance (Hurvitz 1997a: 307-308 n. 16). In accordance with this, Hurvitz discounts the significance of non-Hebrew evidence when it appears to contradict the chronological development in Hebrew (e.g. בִּין ['fine linen'] in the ninth-century Kilamuwa inscription [Hurvitz 1967 and see below]; בֵּית עֵלָם ['tomb'] in the eighth-century Deir 'Alla inscription [Hurvitz 1992: 66 n. 25]; cf. the discussion of קִבְל in Hurvitz 1974b: 44 n. 36 now superseded by developments in Amarna philology; and of the form מִדְּלָךְ in Mesha 14-15: Hurvitz 1982: 50 n. 76).

monarchic period, and that LBH is later, that is, post-exilic. The conclusion is drawn that there is thus no way linguistically that the SBH sources could in fact have been composed after the exile.

2. *The Inscriptions as a Chronological Fixed Point*

I will first discuss the idea that the language of the inscriptions proves that works composed in SBH are pre-exilic. In its simplest form the argument is that the Hebrew inscriptions show us what pre-exilic Hebrew looked like, while sources like the Dead Sea Scrolls show us what post-exilic Hebrew looked like. I will for the moment take for granted that the inscriptions have a close link with SBH, a claim which we will investigate in the third section of this study.

Is it implausible that SBH could be post-exilic? The answer to this must be 'No'. It is quite possible that there were several different contemporary styles of literary Hebrew in the post-exilic period. Just because, in general, LBH represents a typologically later form of Hebrew, does not mean that it could not have been used contemporarily with the typologically older SBH. Furthermore, the post-exilic period was long enough for diachronic developments to occur. It is possible, for example, to imagine diachronic developments that might mark Hellenistic period Hebrew as different from earlier Persian period Hebrew.

Since it is not *a priori* impossible that the various varieties of BH all had their roots in the post-exilic period, we have seen the external sources invoked in order to prove that SBH really is from a chronologically earlier period. However, even if we take for granted that the Hebrew inscriptions have a closer relationship with SBH than with LBH, does this fact prove that SBH *cannot* be post-exilic?

The major problem with using external sources in the current debate is the large gap in the middle of the period under discussion. The Hebrew inscriptions date almost exclusively to the monarchic period, in particular the eighth–early sixth centuries BCE. None of the Dead Sea Scrolls manuscripts is considered to be older than the third century BCE (Cross 1998: 387). The other Hebrew sources mentioned by Hurvitz as 'External controls for the post-classical phase of BH'—Ben Sira, the Bar Kochba letters, and MH (Hurvitz 1997a: 310)—are even later. For the period stretching from the sixth to the third centuries BCE, which includes the whole Persian period, we have almost no extra-biblical evidence for Hebrew at all (Naveh and Greenfield 1984: 122). Since we have almost no idea, on the basis of external sources, what any sort of Hebrew in the Persian period looked

like, we cannot exclude the possibility that the sort of Hebrew being used in the inscriptions from the monarchic period continued to be used at least for a while after the exile. This was the view, for example, of S.R. Driver. For him, 'the great turning-point in Hebrew style falls in the age of *Nehemiah*'. He adds in a footnote: 'And not, as is sometimes supposed, the Captivity. This appears with especial clearness from Zech., the style of which, even in the parts which are certainly post-exilic, is singularly pure' (S.R. Driver 1913a: 505 with n. 1).

To fill in the gap created by the absence of extra-biblical evidence of Hebrew from the Persian period, Hurvitz lays stress on the much better represented Aramaic evidence. In particular he mentions the fifth-century BCE Elephantine papyri, which he notes 'display numerous linguistic features which, within BH, are exclusively attested in... "Late Biblical Hebrew"' (Hurvitz 1999: 27*). It is certainly valid to refer to the Aramaic evidence given not only its Jewish context, but also the strong inter-relationship between Aramaic and Hebrew. The Aramaic texts show the strong impact which the Aramaic *lingua franca* had on the language of a book such as Chronicles (Bendavid 1967–71, I: 71–72). However, the issue at present is whether the *absence* of such Aramaic influence proves that a BH work cannot have been written during the Persian period. The answer must be 'No'. We cannot demonstrate that the Aramaic forms had already penetrated Hebrew at the time when they are attested in Aramaic. Indeed it is hard to find examples in the literature on LBH where it is even argued that the Aramaism in question is late within Aramaic.⁴ Nor can we demonstrate that such Aramaisms penetrated all varieties of literary Hebrew in the Persian period. Some scribes or scribal schools may have been more open or exposed to Aramaic influence than others. Thus, while

4. One of the exceptions is Landes' discussion of Aramaisms in Jonah (Landes 1982: 147–57). C.L. Seow has recently attempted to date Qoheleth to the fifth century, partly on the basis 'that a number of the terms are found in Official Aramaic but not in earlier inscriptions (Old Aramaic). Significantly, there is a significant cluster of terms, particularly economic expressions, all occurring in fifth- and fourth-century documents' (Seow 1996: 654). However, his discussion, while erudite, seems to be methodologically flawed. Seow provides no example of a linguistic contrast with an Old Aramaic term, nor does he make a case that Old Aramaic would have had opportunity to use any of the terms he discusses. In regard to the economic terms he focusses on, it is more likely that these terms are first attested in Aramaic in fifth- and fourth-century texts simply because that is the first time that we have a significant number of economic texts in Aramaic, in contrast to the earlier period. Nor, for that matter do we have pre-exilic Hebrew economic texts.

the Aramaic sources are valuable, they do not give us direct evidence of any contemporary variety of Hebrew.⁵

Finally, we should note an inherent weakness of the whole enterprise of dating language. Even if one sort of Hebrew is well attested in external sources from any particular period, that does not prove that that was the only sort of Hebrew in existence at the time. All it proves is that that was the chosen style for that sort of writing. The more genres of writing that are attested, the more we can claim to know about styles of writing in a particular period. Thus, we are relatively well informed about the Hellenistic era due to the discovery of the Dead Sea Scrolls. The scrolls from cave 1 at Qumran present a larger corpus of Hebrew than all the epigraphic material from the preceding eras. On the basis of that knowledge we could feel confident to declare that we know what written Hebrew of that period looked like. But we would be wrong, since we would be unprepared for the distinctively different features of Copper Scroll Hebrew (from cave 3) or 4QMMT Hebrew (from cave 4). Linguistic dating deals with probabilities, not certainties.

The idea of a pre-exilic SBH and a post-exilic LBH arose naturally out of the critical consensus on the dating of many of the biblical books. It is, however, quite a different question to ask whether the linguistic evidence can exclude other datings of the biblical literature. Likewise, the Hebrew inscriptions demonstrate that it is plausible, by and large, that the language of the Bible was formulated in the monarchic period. They cannot, however, prove that any of the biblical books must have been written in the pre-exilic period.

5. Hurvitz has pointed out the pitfalls of using the Elephantine texts to argue about the chronology of Hebrew words: 'we must always bear in mind that although the Elephantine papyri were *written down* in the fifth century B.C.E., the language employed in these texts was not *created* suddenly in the Persian period... It is, therefore, perfectly clear that Elephantine Aramaic on the one hand and Biblical Hebrew on the other, even when exhibiting similar (or identical) linguistic usages, could have drawn, independently and at different times, on a common third source, earlier than them both' (Hurvitz 1983a: 92). He is arguing against Levine (1982: 127-29) who used the Elephantine evidence to argue that the P word רגל ('military unit') is no earlier than the Persian period. Note also other problems caused by the Elephantine evidence. For example, while it is claimed that the term עדה for 'congregation' is not used in Persian period Hebrew, for instance Chronicles (Hurvitz 1970-71), it is attested a number of times in Elephantine texts (Hoftijzer and Jongeling 1995, II: 828). A full study seems called for. Note also the remarks of Rendsburg, above, against using the Aramaic sources to date Hebrew texts, and the comments below in n. 15, and sections 3.4.1.8 and 3.4.1.35.

3. *The Inscriptions, Standard Biblical Hebrew and Late Biblical Hebrew*

3.1. *Methodological Issues*

We have seen the scholars discussed above draw conclusions from the assumption that the language of the inscriptions from the monarchic period has strong and unmistakable links with SBH. However, I am not aware of any attempts to substantiate this assumption in detail. Often the relationship of SBH with the inscriptions is taken as self-evident. One of the most important statements is in Torczyner's publication of the Lachish letters. Torczyner states that the language of the letters is 'pure Biblical Hebrew, bearing a striking resemblance to the language of the books of Kings and Jeremiah' (Torczyner 1938: 17; cf. Albright 1939: 20-21). However, Torczyner does not attempt to substantiate this claim. Instead he immediately turns to describing the ways in which the language of the texts differs from what is known from the Bible. Torczyner's statement is, however, understandable for 1938. As he himself states (Torczyner 1938: 15), the Lachish letters were the first substantial find of a clearly biblical-type Hebrew in an inscription. Previously, apart from the Siloam Tunnel inscription, discovered in 1880 (which has a number of non-SBH forms, see below), scholars had been faced with the peculiarities of the Gezer Calendar (found in 1908) or of the Samaria Ostraca (found in 1910). From that point of view, it is understandable that Torczyner stressed the biblical nature of the language. He was not, however, concerned with the specific affiliations of the language within BH. His mention of Kings and Jeremiah seems to be merely a reference to the biblical sources most contemporary with the Lachish letters. In effect, Torczyner was simply stating the fact that the Lachish letters were generally in the same sort of Hebrew as the Bible.

There are, in fact, several major problems in trying to establish the relationship of the inscriptions to SBH and LBH. Three problems arise due to the nature of the inscriptional corpus.

First, the inscriptions present a limited corpus in several ways. While we have a reasonable number of short inscriptions, these present a total amount of linguistic material that amounts to less than one percent of the size of the Hebrew Bible, according to one estimate (*DCH*, I: 28). The inscriptions, furthermore, have a focus on issues, such as supply of daily rations, which are not prominent in the biblical material. Thus for the majority of the suggested linguistic contrasts, SBH vs. LBH, the inscriptions

provide no evidence at all. Even such a common linguistic item as the 1st sg. independent pronoun, where the form אֲנִי is said to die out in LBH in favour of אֲנִי (Rooker 1990a: 72-74; cf. Wright 1998: 132-37), is only clearly attested in the inscriptional corpus once (אֲנִי , Arad 88.1; Gogel 1998: 153).

Second, there is the problem that the majority of our inscriptions of any length are dated to the last half century of the kingdom of Judah, c. 625–586 BCE. Into this category fall the ostraca from Meşad Ḥashav-yahu, Arad (largely), and Lachish, which represent the bulk of our knowledge of inscriptional Hebrew in extended contexts. Earlier dated texts of significant linguistic scope include the Gezer Calendar, Siloam Tunnel, Siloam Tomb, and the Khirbet el-Qom and Kuntillet 'Ajrud texts. Yet this group of texts cannot rival the size and linguistic variety of the later texts. While bulky, the Samaria Ostraca do not generally provide a significant amount of linguistic material. Within the context of the biblical texts, therefore, the largest part of inscriptional material is from the period of Jeremiah (c. 627–586 BCE) and Ezekiel (beginning c. 593 BCE). Jeremiah is usually considered an example of SBH. However, it is noteworthy that within the language of Jeremiah, there are what might be called the early signs of the appearance of LBH (cf. Wright 1998: 258, 270). Even more importantly, Ezekiel is commonly described as exhibiting a transitional form of language from SBH to LBH (Hurvitz 1982; Rooker 1990a). In other words, an important part of the inscriptional corpus comes from a period when, even according to a traditional reading of the sources, LBH was already beginning to appear. Polzin (1976: 4), in fact, refers to the Lachish and Arad ostraca as 'late Hebrew'. On the basis of the biblical evidence, therefore, we might expect these inscriptions to exhibit a mixture of LBH elements among the SBH elements. The evidence from texts such as the Lachish and Arad ostraca is thus somewhat ambiguous if one is trying to demonstrate the close links of the inscriptions with SBH.

Third, it is reasonable to ask in what way the inscriptions are relevant, if at all, to the discussion. It is widely acknowledged that the inscriptions generally represent different genres to those preserved in the biblical literature. In a previous study I dubbed the inscriptions as 'Official Hebrew' as opposed to the 'Literary Hebrew' of the Bible (I. Young 1993: 103-13). If we are indeed dealing with a different variety of Hebrew, various alternative possibilities present themselves. Did LBH forms perhaps appear in Official Hebrew earlier than Literary Hebrew? Or was Literary Hebrew more open to linguistic variety than the more mundane style? In other

words, we may not be able to make a simple equation of inscriptional Hebrew with BH.

Another important problem relates to the nature of the LBH corpus. Very seldom is it the case that linguistic form X is confined to SBH, while in LBH it is completely replaced by form Y. This would be the easiest sort of case when arguing that the inscriptions have a close relationship with SBH, since the mere appearance of X, not Y, would constitute strong evidence. The reality and the complexity of the situation is illustrated by the well-regarded book by Rooker on Ezekiel (Rooker 1990a). Rooker is an especially good representative since he builds on the insights of both Avi Hurvitz and Robert Polzin (Polzin 1976). Rooker presents 37 linguistic items (20 grammatical and 17 lexical) as characteristic of LBH. Of these, only two (lexical) cases arguably represent the situation where the SBH form X is totally replaced by form Y in LBH. One of these is the replacement of SBH שֶׁשׁ by LBH כֹּרֶץ for 'fine linen'. Hesitation is caused in this case by the appearance of the SBH form in the poem about the good wife in Prov. 31.22, which is often considered 'late' on other grounds (cf. Wolters 1985: 585-86), and the appearance of the LBH form in the Phoenician Kilamuwa inscription (l. 12/13), securely dated to the ninth century BCE (cf. Hawkins 1982: 395-98). The second case, SBH מַרְצֶפֶת/קֶרֶקֶת vs. LBH רִצְפָּה ('pavement') involves a total of 16 occurrences for all three words combined, 11 of which are found in Ezekiel (five cases of רִצְפָּה) and 1 Kings 6–7 (six instances of קֶרֶקֶת).

Ten of the remaining linguistic forms in Rooker's discussion involve the case where linguistic item X continues into LBH, but is joined by a new synonym Y. When investigating the relationship of SBH to the inscriptions, what are we to make of a case when X is found in a Hebrew inscription? Do we stress the fact that it is not Y? Or simply note that X is attested in all strata of Hebrew, and therefore its appearance in the inscriptions has no significance at all? In contrast, the attestation of form Y in the inscriptions would be more significant.

The remaining 25 of Rooker's 37 LBH forms are cases where both linguistic forms X and Y are attested in SBH texts, but form Y becomes proportionately much more significant in LBH. Since both X and Y are attested in all strata, can we see any significance in the appearance of X in the inscriptions? With a small corpus, can we meaningfully discuss issues relating to the relative proportions of linguistic forms?

With these difficulties in mind, I can now turn to a detailed discussion of the inscriptional corpus. The aim is to be comprehensive, but I am under

no illusions that I have covered all relevant forms. Hopefully at least, the following lists can serve as the basis for future research.

3.2. *Links with SBH*

Here I discuss linguistic forms found in the inscriptions which have been suggested to be links with SBH. I have added other forms that have interesting patterns of distribution within BH. I have, however, avoided cases not suggested in the literature where it is clear that there is no linguistic opposition with a LBH form (see, e.g., Hurvitz 1973: 76). Thus, for example, the word *אָמֶשׁ* ('yesterday') is found in Lachish letter 3.6. The word is not found in LBH. However, this is best explained by the fact that 'yesterday' happens not to be expressed in the LBH corpus. In this case there is no linguistic opposition between the SBH term and another term which fills the same linguistic slot in LBH. Absence of linguistic opposition rules out other links between the inscriptions and SBH. Thus the word *נֶבֶל* ('jar, bottle') as a wine container is common in the Samaria Ostraca and SBH. However, no wine containers seem to be referred to in core LBH texts. *גֶּרֶן* ('axe, pick[?']') is used in Siloam Tunnel II. 2 and 4, and four times in SBH, but not in LBH. However, such a tool does not seem to be mentioned at all in LBH.

The organization of this and the following sections is roughly alphabetical according to (1) the name of the inscription or (2) the title of the general discussion.

3.2.1. *Absence of Persian Loanwords.* Although the classification of a Persian loanword is sometimes difficult (I. Young 1993: 69-71), it is indisputable that a concentration of suspected Persian loanwords is found in works which deal explicitly with the Persian period such as Esther. However, not all LBH works have a concentration of suspected Persian words. In regard to the large book of Chronicles, for example, it has recently been noted that 'there are very few Persian words in the entire work' (Peltonen 2001: 239). There are, moreover, no Persian words in the post-exilic books of Haggai, Zechariah, and Malachi (Seow 1996: 649). Persian words are not an inevitability in Persian period texts therefore. More surprisingly, Persian loanwords can be suggested in SBH texts, such as *פְּרוּרִים* ('precincts[?']') in 2 Kgs 23.11 (Ellenbogen 1962: 137-38; KB, III: 962), or *פְּלִדוֹת* ('steel') in Nah. 2.4 (KB, III: 929). One wonders if more might be suggested if it was not presupposed that EBH is pre-Persian era? Note the attitude expressed in Driver's comment on Deut. 33.2: 'But *דָּה* "law" is a *Persian* word... it is next to impossible that it can have been

used in Heb[rew] when this Blessing was written' (S.R. Driver 1895: 393 [emphasis in original]).⁶

The appearance of Persian loanwords in a text has usually been taken as strong evidence for dating that text. On the basis of the Persian words in Kings and Nahum, therefore, one could argue that the linguistic evidence points to a date of composition for the Primary History and (at least some of) the 'pre-exilic' Latter Prophets in the Persian period. However, it seems more sensible at present to stress that even granting that all the suggested Persian words are indeed Persian, this does not lead inevitably to the conclusion that the works containing them were thus first composed in the Persian period. First of all, the language of the biblical texts has been updated during scribal transmission. At the very least, individual late words might have been introduced by later scribes (cf. I. Young 2001b: 130). Second, the idea that Persian words could only have come into Hebrew in the Persian or later periods is questionable. Assyrian deportations had quite likely settled Iranians in the vicinity of the kingdom of Judah by the late eighth century BCE, for example in Ashdod (Na'aman and Zadok 1988; Na'aman 1993: 108-10; cf. I. Young 2001b: 130 n. 50). Is this the origin of the use of 'Ashdodite' as a term for 'foreign language' in Neh. 13.24? Interaction with Iranians would explain how a few Persian loanwords can be found even in supposedly pre-exilic texts like Kings, Nahum (and, perhaps, Qoheleth; cf. I. Young 1993: 140-57). A heavy concentration of Persian words would be a feature of those works which deal intimately with Persian affairs, above all Esther. Other books, including post-exilic books like Haggai, Zechariah, and Malachi, avoided using them completely. Thus the failure to find Persian words in the inscriptions does not link them exclusively to SBH works of supposed pre-exilic origin.

3.2.2. *אל vs. על.* Rooker (1990a: 127-31) argues that the preposition *על* became more prominent in LBH at the expense of *אל* ('to'). He points to the Lachish letters as illustrating the EBH situation (Rooker 1990a: 131 n. 21). In general the inscriptional corpus has a predominance of *אל* (46 times, as against 14 cases of *על*). Note, however, that Gogel discusses a

6. As another example, note Seow's useful discussion of Persian words in Qoheleth, and BH in general. While he goes to lengths to cast doubt on the Persian origin of *פְּרוּרִים* and *פְּלִדוֹת* (Seow 1996: 648), presumably because they are in pre-exilic texts, he says that 'there can be no question that the word *פְּרָדִים* is ultimately of Persian origin' (p. 649), presumably because it only occurs in what to him are post-exilic texts, even though 'we should expect Old Persian *g* to appear as Hebrew *z* or *d*; Hebrew *s* should go back to Old Persian *s*, not *g*' (p. 649 n. 38).

couple of cases (Arad 3.3-5; 24.14-16) where עַל may appear in place of אֶל (Gogel 1998: 213-14; cf. Layton 1990: 634 n. 2), that is, the LBH situation (cf. below 3.3.1.16). In this case do we emphasize that SBH sometimes also has עַל for אֶל? Or do we claim a link with LBH? Rooker notes that עַל for אֶל is quite noticeable in Jeremiah, whose setting is contemporary with the Arad letters (Rooker 1990a: 131), and even more noticeable in their other contemporary, Ezekiel (Rooker 1990a: 131). In a case such as this, can the inscriptions be even expected to agree closely with SBH?

3.2.3. נָתַן ('give')—Arad 1.2; 2.1; 7.2; 11.2. The infinitive absolute used as a command is not attested in LBH according to Eskhult (2000: 90). However, it may be found in Neh. 7.3 according to Ehrens-värd (in his contribution to the present volume, pp. 169-70). It also occurs at least once in Ben Sira (Van Peursen 2000: 225-26). More importantly, several scholars have suggested that the Arad form is actually an irregular, non-BH form of the imperative, which normally in BH drops the initial *nun* (Sarfatti 1982: 71; Gai 1996: 530-31; cf. below 3.4.1.2).

3.2.4. אִם...וְנָתַתָּ ('if...then you will give')—Arad 2.7. Rooker (1990a: 120-23) notes a tendency in LBH for the apodosis of a conditional sentence to be expressed by an imperfect verb, as opposed to the *waw* consecutive plus perfect in EBH. Further, Rooker argues that 'the apodosis in LBH tends to be asyndetic [i.e. without *waw*] in contrast with the syndetic apodosis in EBH' (p. 120). However, Rooker makes no claim to exhaustive treatment of the topic, nor does he claim that this sequence was exclusive to EBH. Van Peursen (2000: 222-24) suggests some important modifications to Rooker's statement, and notes the use of the imperfect in the apodosis in some EBH texts. In contrast to the Arad example, note perhaps the sequence in Lachish 3.11-12: 'If (אִם) I read it, afterwards (אַחֲרָיו)—no *waw*) I could repeat(?) it (אֶחָדֶנָּה)' (Renz and Rölli-g 1995, I: 418; cf. I. Young 1998a: 412 n. 10). However, Van Peursen (2000: 223) notes that 'in SBH syndesis is only the rule when the apodosis has a consecutive verb form'. Therefore, the absence of *waw* on אַחֲרָיו is not a specific LBH feature, *contra* Rooker's argument.

3.2.5. בְּמִדָּה ('before')—Arad 5.12. This word never occurs in the core LBH works such as Chronicles. However, it does appear, for example in Ezekiel. Furthermore, what is the LBH equivalent? לְפָנַי ('before') used in

a temporal sense is rare in LBH sources, being more common in SBH. There are no relevant parallel passages in Samuel-Kings//Chronicles, and the Targumic translation לְפָנַי is rare in the Bible, and not found in the core LBH texts (Isa. 47.7; Prov. 8.26).

3.2.6. מְהֵרָה ('quickly')—Arad 12.3; 17.5. This word does not occur in the core LBH books, and in books suspected of being LBH it occurs only in Qoh. 4.12; 8.11; Joel 4.4. LBH uses the verb, but alongside it uses the root בָּהַל (Wright 1998: 138-41).

3.2.7. בֵּית יְהוָה ('house of the Lord')—Arad 18.9; Moussaieff Ostrakon 1.4. Dobbs-Allsopp (1998: 22) cites these two inscriptions while arguing that 'house of the Lord' represents the SBH equivalent of LBH בֵּית הָאֱלֹהִים ('house of God'). However, 'house of the Lord' is well attested also in LBH sources, and thus should be seen as a 'common Hebrew' feature, not a specific marker of SBH.

3.2.8. פָּן ('lest')—Arad 24.16, 20. Rooker (1990a: 172-73; cf. Hurvitz 1972a: 147-48; Wright 1998: 86-90) suggests that in LBH the expression לֹא-פָן appeared in the semantic range of a number of SBH expressions, including פָּן. It is noteworthy that פָּן is very rare in LBH books, occurring only once in Chronicles (1 Chron. 10.4//1 Sam. 31.4) and not at all in Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther, or Daniel, nor in Qoheleth, Song of Songs or Ezekiel. However, the picture is complicated by other considerations. Thus פָּן is almost as rare in the SBH Kings as it is in the LBH Chronicles, appearing only twice (2 Kgs 2.16; 10.23). Note the parallel passage 2 Kgs 18.32//Isa. 36.18 where Kings has כִּי in place of the Isaiah text's פָּן. Further, פָּן is very common in the LBH of Ben Sira (Van Peursen 1999b: 230-31) which may be related to its common use in Proverbs. Finally, we note the occurrence in the post-exilic (but not heavily LBH) Malachi in a verse which has been seen as part of a canon-conscious (hence late-editorial?) 'ending' of the prophetic canon (Mal. 3.24; Chapman 2000: 112).

3.2.9. בִּזְוֶה ('in this place')—Deutsch and Heltzer 1994: 29. The locative sense of בִּזְוֶה and מִזְוֶה is not attested in LBH (Hurvitz 1982: 89-90). It is likely we have an example of מִזְוֶה ('from this place [from there]') in Lachish 3.18 (Torczyner 1938: 59). However, other readings and translations have been proposed (cf. Renz and Rölli-g 1995, I: 418).

3.2.10. ירח ('month')—*Gezer Calendar*,⁷ *passim*; *Arad* 20.2(?).⁸ The word is not used in core LBH, which prefers the common biblical word שָׁחַד. However, note Zech. 11.8; Job 3.6; 7.3; 29.2; 39.2, and, in Biblical Aramaic: Dan. 4.26; Ezra 6.15.

3.2.11. ספר ('letter') *Lachish*, *passim*. Rooker (1990a: 139-41; cf. Hurvitz 1972a: 58-59) suggests that in LBH a new word for 'written document', כתב, joined the EBH words ספר and מכתב (which was rare). He says further: 'Consistent with this diachronic distribution is the lexical preference of the Lachish letters of the early sixth century. In these letters the early term ספר occurs repeatedly, while the late term כתב is not attested'. Interestingly Rooker is contrasting the linguistic usage of the Lachish letters with that of Ezekiel, whose career overlaps with the time when the Lachish letters were written. In any case, note that ספר remains in common use in LBH. In the inscriptional corpus ספר is found 13 times, only in the Lachish letters. Outside of Lachish, it is not out of the question that the LBH noun כתב does in fact appear in Khirbet el-Qom 1.1 (Zevit 1984: 43-44; I. Young 1993: 109; cf. below 3.3.1.7).

3.2.12. העת ('the time')—*Lachish* 6.2. Polzin (1976: 42-43) notes that the pluralization of certain nouns is a feature of LBH. The word עתים is one of these. The plural is only found in EBH once, with a suffix (Isa. 33.6). עת is found in the singular in Lachish, like the usual EBH form. However, since עת is often singular in LBH too, this is not an exclusive marker of SBH, but rather a feature of 'common Hebrew'.

3.2.13. נא ('please')—*Lachish* 3.5(?),⁹ 6.5. Polzin (1976: 145; cf. Ben-david 1967-71: 67; Dobbs-Allsopp 1998: 24) points out that נא is rare in LBH. However, it does occur eight times in Chronicles, seven in Ezra and

7. The relevance of the Gezer Calendar is debatable. While some view it as Judahite (Diringer and Brock 1968: 39), others view it as representing another southern dialect (Gibson 1973: 1), a northern dialect (Cross and Freedman 1952: 47), or wonder whether it is non-Israelite (e.g. Kutscher 1982: 67; Schüle 2000: 26 n. 2). While my study (I. Young 1992b) demonstrated its links with ABH, it did not prove that such a style was exclusive to Israel. We remain largely ignorant of Phoenician literature, for example.

8. Gibson (1973: 51) and (Aharoni 1981: 40) read the word in the Arad text, but recently Renz and Röhlig (1995, I: 386) do not. Gogel (1998: 391) notes both readings.

9. The reading in Lachish 3.5 is considered 'most likely' by Renz and Röhlig (1995, I: 417), but other readings have been proposed.

Nehemiah, and two in Daniel. Note also nine occurrences total in Ezekiel, Lamentations, Song of Songs and Qoheleth. Furthermore, one might ask whether one (or two) occurrences only in the inscriptional corpus is evidence of a link with SBH, or with the rarity of the form in LBH.

3.2.14. קמו ('arise')—*Lachish* 13.1. Rooker (1990a: 149-52) notes that in LBH עמד begins to intrude into the semantic field of קום. He suggests that it is significant that 'The later parallel עמד however, does not occur in these [Lachish] letters from the early sixth century' (Rooker 1990a: 149 n. 83). Again one notes the peculiarity of such use of the Lachish letters in a work on LBH features in the language of their contemporary Ezekiel. In any case, since קום remains common in LBH the question arises again whether its appearance in the inscription (עמד is not attested) is a link with SBH or just an insignificant feature of 'common Hebrew'.

3.2.15. לקח vs. הביא. Polak (1997-98: 142-44) notes that לקח ('take') is relatively rare in LBH. He argues that its main replacement is הביא. In the inscriptions לקח is found eight times (G.I. Davies 1991: 418) while neither הביא nor any of the other substitutes for לקח are found. Furthermore, none of the occurrences of לקח need have the additional LBH sense of 'buy', although 'buy' has in fact been suggested (Albright 1941: 20, on Lachish 3.18). Nevertheless, לקח ('take') is found in all types of Hebrew, so this is not an exclusive link with SBH.

3.2.16. מן ('from'). Polzin (1976: 66) notes the tendency of Chronicles to leave מן unassimilated before a noun without an article. The inscriptions present 78 cases of assimilated nun in this environment (57 in the Samaria Ostraca), with only two exceptions, both uncertain readings: Arad 26.2; Beersheba 1.2. However, among the Masoretic Text of the Hebrew Bible (MT) forms of the biblical books it is actually only Chronicles and to a lesser extent Job and Daniel which have a significant proportion of unassimilated מן (cf. Rezetko's contribution to the present volume, pp. 230-31). Outside of the MT, the Qumran 4QCant^b manuscript of the Song of Songs also exhibits this feature very strongly (I. Young 2001b: 122-23). Esther, on the contrary, has no examples of unassimilated nun in 29 occurrences. Further, sporadic occurrences are found in almost all EBH books. It is thus doubtful whether unassimilated nun is a general feature of LBH.

3.2.17. שלח שלחה ('I have indeed sent')—*papMurabba'at* 17a.1. Polzin (1976: 43-44) claimed that the infinitive absolute used with a finite verb

was almost missing from Chronicles. However, Rendsburg (1980a: 67-68) has pointed out that it is common in the core LBH book of Esther and that its absence should thus not be considered a feature of LBH in general.

3.2.18. וזה היה דבר הנקבה—*Siloam Tunnel 1*. Ehrensävrd (1997: 37) points out that this sort of introduction (lit.: 'now this was the manner of the tunnel') is found three times in SBH, but not in LBH, as part of his argument that the inscriptions are close to SBH. However, he provides no LBH equivalent nor any reference to a place where such an introduction would have been appropriate in LBH. Further, all the SBH examples he cites are lacking היה even when the reference is clearly to a past event (e.g. 1 Kgs 9.15). Hence this may be better classed as a form independent of BH (cf. below 3.4.1.43).

3.2.19. ובעוד ('while still')—*Siloam Tunnel 2*. Ehrensävrd (1997: 37) also cites this form and notes its absence from LBH. LBH would seem to prefer simple עוד (ו), which is, of course, common in SBH also.

3.2.20. וילכו ('and they flowed [went]')—*Siloam Tunnel 4*. Hurvitz (1982: 48-52) argues that the piel of the verb הלך, as opposed to the regular qal form, is late. He points out that the Siloam Tunnel evidences the qal (Hurvitz 1982: 50; the only occurrence of הלך in the inscriptions—see 3.3.1.4). However, as Hurvitz points out: 'The root *hlc* in the *Qal* conjugation occurs frequently (over 1000 times) throughout all of biblical literature: ancient and late...' (Hurvitz 1982: 49). Therefore this is not a special link with SBH.

3.2.21. אשר על הבית ('who was over the house')—*Silwan Tomb 2.1*. This title of a high official is also found on several seals (Layton 1990: 637-41; Gogel 1998: 462, 487, 492). Ehrensävrd (1997: 38) notes its absence from LBH. However, note that the full title is only found in the books of Kings and Isaiah. Most of these references are in the parallel texts about Sennacherib, King of Assyria's attack on Hezekiah of Judah (2 Kgs 18.18, 37; 19.2//Isa. 36.3, 22; 37.2). The other two references are to Arza, at the end of Elah's reign over Israel (1 Kgs 16.9), and Shebna, also in Hezekiah's reign (Isa. 22.15).¹⁰ It is important to note that none of the passages has a

10. A relationship between Shebna and the Siloam Tomb has often been suggested (cf. I. Young 1998a: 422 n. 29).

parallel in Chronicles. Hence the question arises whether Chronicles (or LBH in general) ever had the opportunity to use this form of the title.

A shorter version of the title seems to be על הבית, which occurs in the Joseph story in Genesis 37-50 and in Kings (1 Kgs 4.6; 2 Kgs 15.5; Layton 1990: 633-37). 2 Kings 15.5 has a parallel in 2 Chron. 26.21, where instead of Kings' 'Jotham the king's son was over the house (על הבית)' we have 'Jotham his son was over the house of the king (על בית המלך)'. If these are to be considered variations on אשר על הבית we must note for our current discussion that neither על הבית nor על בית המלך occurs in the inscriptions.

3.2.22. כסף וזהב ('silver and gold')—*Silwan Tomb 2.1*. Ehrensävrd (1997: 37-38) argues that while SBH prefers the order 'silver and gold', LBH prefers 'gold and silver'. However, there is no absolute distinction, only a question of proportions. 'Gold and silver' is not uncommon in EBH texts. LBH also uses both. Thus Chronicles has eight 'silver and gold' alongside its ten 'gold and silver' (Rooker 1990a: 174-75).

3.2.23. אמתה ('his maidservant')—*Silwan Tomb 2.2*. אמת ('maidservant') is almost completely missing from LBH, appearing only, in the plural, in Ezra 2.65//Neh. 7.67. However, its possible parallel שפחה is also rare (Esth. 7.4; 2 Chron. 28.10; cf. Joel 3.2; Qoh. 2.7) and thus it is unclear whether one should see any significance in this.

3.2.24. *Summary*. The overall impression left by the preceding discussion is just how weak is the case for a clear and close link of SBH with the Hebrew inscriptions. Very few strong points have been made. Points 3.2.3 (נתן as infinitive absolute), 3.2.9 (locative זה), and 3.2.19 (ובעוד) seem to be the strongest. In these three, a form unattested or very rare in LBH (which uses a different linguistic form) is found in the inscriptions.

More often the argument is based on the absence of a rare LBH feature from the inscriptions in preference for the common (SBH and LBH) Hebrew form. Examples of this nature could be multiplied beyond those mentioned by other scholars and discussed above. We recall that LBH is basically identical to SBH with additional, special features. Thus while arguments about the absence of special LBH features indicate in what ways the inscriptions are not related to LBH, they do not provide a positive argument that the inscriptions are related in a special way to SBH. A more convincing interpretation of such features is that the inscriptions

simply share the pool of 'common biblical' features with SBH, LBH, and other types of BH such as ABH and QH. This is not an argument for a special link with any of them.

At other times the forms suggested to be distinctively SBH or LBH were found to be not clearly characteristic of one variety of Hebrew. Finally, sometimes SBH forms absent from LBH lacked clear LBH linguistic oppositions.

Thus, while there *are* some special links between the inscriptions and SBH, these are not strong enough to argue a self-evident identity between the two corpora.

3.3. *Links with Late Biblical Hebrew*

I now turn to those linguistic features found in Hebrew inscriptions which might be suggested to be characteristic of LBH. I organize this section into two parts. The first gives those features which have a suggested linguistic opposition against a parallel SBH feature. The second gives those forms which, while found in LBH and not SBH, do not have a demonstrable opposition to a SBH form.

3.3.1. *Late Biblical Hebrew Links with Linguistic Oppositions to Standard Biblical Hebrew*

3.3.1.1. *יין בַּיִת* ('wine: 3 Bath')—*Arad 1.3; 16.5*. Polzin (1976: 58-60) argues that LBH has a tendency to place the substantive before the numeral in apposition, where SBH uses the opposite word order. Weitzman (1996; cf. Hurvitz 1982: 167-68) has pointed out not only that the LBH word order is used in EBH, but also (p. 180) has discussed the inscriptional evidence.

3.3.1.2. *עַל יָד* ('under the command of')—*Arad 24.15*. Polzin (1976: 148; cf. Dobbs-Allsopp 1998: 22) notes that the idiom *עַל יָד* is only found in Chronicles, Ezra, and twice in Jeremiah, as well as in MH. He suggests that it perhaps replaces the EBH *בְּיָד*. Note again how Jeremiah, set contemporary with this Arad ostrakon, shares a form otherwise LBH.

3.3.1.3. *רָצָה* ['he wanted']—*Arad 40.7*. Hurvitz (1972a: 73-78; cf. Wright 1998: 124-28) points out that the word *רָצָה* in SBH has such meanings as 'take pleasure in, be favourable to' (cf. KB, III: 1281). In MH the root develops the sense 'to want', which in BH is expressed by *חָפֵץ*. Hurvitz suggests that the semantic shift occurred under the influence of Aramaic *רָעָה*. Although it does not preserve any cases of the verb *רָצָה* ('to want'), LBH does evidence the noun *רָצוֹן* ('will'), especially in the

phrase *לַעֲשׂוֹת (כ)רָצוֹן* ('to do the will of...'). Although the word is partially reconstructed, all recent commentators find the 'late Aramaism' *רָצָה* ('to want') in *Arad 40.7*, dated to the late eighth century BCE (Aharoni 1981: 71; Ahituv 1992: 88; Renz and Röllig 1995, I: 147; Gogel 1998: 396).

3.3.1.4. *בּוֹא* vs. *הֵלֵךְ*. Polak points out that the verb *הֵלֵךְ* ('go') is relatively rare in LBH, corresponding to a proportionate rise in the frequency of *בּוֹא* ('come'; Polak 1997-98: 144-48). Polak also notes that *הֵלֵךְ* is rare in the inscriptions, occurring in fact only once (Siloam Tunnel l. 4) as against nine occurrences of *בּוֹא* (G.I. Davies 1991: 301) corresponding thus with LBH rather than SBH (Polak 1997-98: 147).

3.3.1.5. *הַכֹּנֵס* ('the one who gathers')—*City of David 2.2, 3* (Naveh 2000: 2-3). Rooker (1990a: 156-58; cf. Hurvitz 1982: 123-25; Wright 1998: 156-60) states that '[t]he verb *כָּנַס*, in the Qal and Piel stems is restricted to LBH passages with the connotation "gather, collect"'. Despite Rooker's strong formulation, one notes the qal participle in Ps. 33.7, a psalm one might consider to represent SBH, as well as the hithpaal in Isa. 28.20. Note further the use of the root in Deut. 32.34 in the Samaritan Pentateuch in place of the MT's *hapax* *כָּנַס*. The SBH oppositions to *כָּנַס*, *קָבַץ* and *אָסַף* (cf. Gezer Calendar 1), continue to be used in LBH as well.

3.3.1.6. *יָרְחוֹ* ('his months[?']')—*Gezer Calendar 1* (twice), 2, 6. Rooker (1990a: 91-93; cf. Polzin 1976: 38-40) states: 'The use of the proleptic pronominal suffix increased in frequency in the history of BH and can be seen as a characteristic of LBH'. However, Rendsburg (1980a: 69) objects that this construction is common in EBH as well. Further, the interpretation of the Gezer form is open to dispute (I. Young 1992b: 363-66; recent discussion in Emerton 1999b).

3.3.1.7. *כְּתִיבָה* ('his inscription')—*Khirbet el-Qom 3.1*. Rooker (1990a: 139-41) states that 'The noun *כְּתִיבָה*...is restricted to Ezekiel, Esther, Daniel, Ezra, Nehemiah, and Chronicles'. Zevit (1984: 43-44; cf. I. Young 1993: 109) has suggested that the noun is found in this eighth-century Khirbet el-Qom tomb inscription. Note, however, that the reading of a verb with an object suffix 'he wrote it' is preferred by most scholars.

3.3.1.8. *בְּעֵת הַזֶּה* ('in this season')—*Lachish 6.2*. The noun *עֵת* is generally feminine in BH. Torczyner (1938: 106-107) discusses possible cases in the biblical text where *עֵת* seems to be masculine. The majority of these (including all those which Torczyner, who believed *עֵת* was always feminine, could not explain away as anything but a scribal error) are found in books with LBH links: Ezekiel, Song of Songs, and Qoheleth. Furthermore,

עַל is taken as masculine in LBH when it is expressed as the plural עַלִּים (cf. 3.2.12), which can be found with masculine adjectives, see Ezra 10.14 (cf. BDB: 773).

3.3.1.9. לַרְפָּה (*'to cause to be slack'*)—*Lachish* 6.6. The normal SBH causative for the root רָפַה is the hiphil stem. The piel may reflect the Aramaic use of the pael stem. Within BH the distribution of the piel is 'late' (Ezra 4.4; Ezek. 1.24, 25; Jer. 38.4; cf. Job 12.21). However, the occurrences in Jeremiah and Ezekiel, while both works reflecting LBH influence, are from texts which date themselves contemporary with the Lachish letters.

3.3.1.10. וָאֵסַן (*'and stored'*)—*Mešad Hashavyahu*¹¹ 1.5, 6-7. The verb וָאֵסַן (*'to store'*) is not found in BH. The cognate noun 'storehouse' is attested in Prov. 3.10 and 4Q416 2.2 from Qumran (*DCH*, I: 346). Since there is a linguistic opposition to SBH וָאֵסַר (*'storehouse'*) a case could be made that this is a feature of LBH.

3.3.1.11. וָאֵסַן (*'and stored'*)—*Mešad Hashavyahu* 1.5, 6-7. Rooker (1990a: 100-102) argues that 'a distinctive feature of LBH is the diminished employment of the *waw* consecutive tense... Accompanying the tendency to avoid the consecutive tense in LBH is the increase in the use of the simple tense with *waw* conjunction.' Scholars have long noted what Rooker calls 'the reluctance to use the *waw* consecutive tense' in the Hebrew inscriptions, particularly the Lachish letters (Albright 1939: 21; Baumgartner 1940-41: 609; Rooker 1990: 100 n. 123). It is notable that while the *waw* consecutive plus perfect is used eight times in the Arad letters, and *waw* consecutive plus imperfect is common in the *Mešad Hashavyahu* ostrakon, *waw* consecutives are very rare elsewhere.¹² Nevertheless, it is hard to find examples where simple *waw* with a verb is found where *waw* consecutive might be expected.¹³ One might explain this as due to the

11. The relevance of the *Mešad Hashavyahu* material for JH might be questioned, since neither Judahite political control of the region, nor a background of biblical law for the case discussed can be taken as certain (see recently Hübner 1997). Although we know little about the neighbouring languages, it is clear that all the inscriptions written in Canaanite (including Philistine, see the Ekron text) were in a language very similar to each other and to BH, and hence it is difficult to be sure we have 'Hebrew' here.

12. I found *waw* consecutive plus perfect at Arad 2.7-8; 3.5, 8; 7.5-6 (*waw* reconstructed); 16.4; 17.3-4; 24.13 (probably), 14-15 (or imperative?); Moussaieff 2.3, 4; and *waw* consecutive plus imperfect at Lachish 4.6-7; *Mešad Hashavyahu* 1.4, 5, 7, 8; Siloam Tunnel I. 4.

13. Apart from the current form, only the dubious case of *waw* plus imperfect in Kuntillet 'Ajrud 8.1 (context unclear; Phoenician?)

nature of the texts—very seldom are two 'consecutive' actions described. However, Isserlin has suggested that an important factor is the predominance of inverted sentence structures in the inscriptions, that is, an avoidance of placing the verb in sentence initial position where the *waw* consecutive appears (Isserlin 1972: 200-202; cf. I. Young 1993: 104). In any case, there are numerous cases of simple *waw* plus perfect in EBH (see Rezetko's contribution to the present volume, pp. 233-35), and the converted tenses are used regularly in LBH. Also, 'The decline of *way-yiqtol* in [LBH] is significant, but...there is no indication that it declines in usage in favour of *w^eqatal*' (Eskhult 2000: 84). Note also, that an alternative interpretation of the *Mešad Hashavyahu* form is as an infinitive absolute (e.g. Diringer and Brock 1968: 42; cf. Gogel 1998: 267 n. 30). The infinitive absolute in place of a finite verb is slightly more common in LBH than SBH (Eskhult 2000: 90), but still well attested in EBH (Rendsburg 2002b: 37-38). Schüle (2000: 133-34) has recently argued against seeing וָאֵסַן as an infinitive.¹⁴

3.3.1.12. קָצַר הָיָה (*'he was harvesting'*)—*Mešad Hashavyahu* 1.3. Rooker (1990a: 108-109) states: 'The use of the copula הָיָה with the participle, a common feature of MH [cf. Sarfatti 1992: 56-57], enjoyed an increased frequency in the literature of LBH'. However, the issue is merely increased frequency, not absence of this feature from SBH. Muraoka (1999: 194-201) has in fact argued that it is not uncommon in SBH, so much so that 'it is hardly the case that the syntagm is characteristic of Late Biblical Hebrew' (p. 195). Ehrensverd (in his contribution to this volume: p. 171) disputes this last claim, but does not dispute that there are a significant number of SBH occurrences.¹⁵ Finally, we should note the alternative reading of the inscription: 'Your servant is a harvester (קָצַר עַבְדִּי). Your servant was... (עַבְדִּי קָצַר)' (cf. Renz and Rölli 1995, I: 324).

3.3.1.13. מִן (*'from'*) *unassimilated*. As noted above (3.2.16) there are a couple of suggested places where the preposition מִן (*'from'*) is *unassimilated* before a noun without a definite article, a supposed tendency of LBH. However, the readings are dubious.

14. Schüle (2000: 133-42) proposes that the so-called 'perfect consecutive' in fact represents a stative form used for circumstantial clauses.

15. Dobbs-Allsopp (1998: 30-31) points out that הָיָה plus participle is not attested in Aramaic before the Hermopolis letters (c. 500 BCE). This shows commendable attention to the inner chronology of Aramaic (cf. n. 4, above). However, what are we to make of this? Is it evidence that SBH is post-exilic? Or that Aramaic evidence must be handled very cautiously when talking about the chronology of Hebrew?

3.3.1.14. *אֲשִׁיָּהּ הַמֶּלֶךְ* ('Ashiyahu the king')—Moussaieff Ostrakon 1.1-2.¹⁶ The word order 'X the king' is suggested to be LBH, in contrast to the SBH 'the king X' (Kropat 1909: 74; D. Talshir 1992: 280). However, as Rezetko points out (see his article in the present volume, pp. 229-30) the 'LBH' order is found in EBH texts, while some LBH books like Esther use the 'SBH' order completely.

3.3.1.15. *Nominal style*. Frank Polak (1997-98; 1998; 2002a; and in his contribution to the present volume, pp. 47-49) has argued that a 'nominal' style, that is, a high proportion of nouns to verbs, is a characteristic of LBH. Polak (e.g. 1997-98: 51-52) also points out the highly nominal style of Hebrew inscriptions: of course, there are no verbs in many administrative documents like the Samaria Ostraca. Polak himself sees this as due to the genre, and would suggest that his findings are relevant for the chronology of literary Hebrew only. The later strata of SBH, like the Jeremiah *Vita*, and LBH, are increasingly under the influence of the scribal style of administrative Hebrew, whereas the earlier narratives, like the Samson narrative, are under the influence of oral literary style.

In any case, one may question whether Polak's data require a chronological interpretation. He points out that the verbal style, that is with a high proportion of verbs to nouns, which he sees as a feature of early narratives, is also found in late sources such as the later Midrashim and some medieval narratives (Polak 2002a; see also his contribution to the present volume, pp. 59, 81). The operative factor then is not date but nature of source. Works using oral traditions as their source tend to preserve some features of oral style; works using written sources, or heavily reworked by their scribes, reflect a more scribal style. Polak has thus discovered important information relating to the origins of biblical traditions, but it is not relevant to the question of chronology.

3.3.1.16. *עַל* for *אֶל*. As noted above (3.2.2) several cases of the supposed LBH tendency to use *עַל* in place of the preposition *אֶל* ('to') have been suggested.

3.3.1.17. *בְּמֵאָתָיִם וְאַלְף אַמָּה* ('for 200 and 1000 [i.e. 1200] cubits')—Siloam Tunnel 5. S.R. Driver (1913b: x) points out that the order of the numerals, with the smaller first, is rare in the Hebrew Bible, except in P,

16. There is debate regarding the authenticity of the Moussaieff Ostraca, see: Berlejung and Schüle 1998; C.A. Rollston (1998 [a section that appears within Bordreuil, Israel and Pardee 1998]); Eph'al and Naveh 1998. Part of the case against the ostraca has rested on the presence of 'late' Hebrew elements in them. In view of the discussion in this section, we can see that such an argument cannot be decisive.

Ezekiel and Chronicles. However, as is usual with LBH features, the construction is also attested in EBH sources (e.g. 1 Kgs 5.12).

3.3.1.18. *מֵאָתָא אַמָּה* ('100 cubits')—Siloam Tunnel 5-6. S.R. Driver (1913b: x) further notes that the use of the number '100' in the form *מֵאָתָא* is common in the P source, which has been argued to have links with LBH (Polzin 1976). Outside of the Pentateuch *מֵאָתָא* is only found in books with a concentration of LBH features: Qoh. 8.12; Esth. 1.4; Neh. 5.11; 2 Chron. 25.9.

3.3.1.19. *זָהָב אֹפִיר* ('gold of Ophir')—Tell Qasile 2.1. The expression 'gold of Ophir' occurs four times in the Hebrew Bible. Three times (Isa. 13.12; Ps. 45.10; Job 28.16) the word 'gold' is expressed by the rare word *כָּהָם*. Only in the LBH of Chronicles (1 Chron. 29.4), and in this inscription, is the common word *זָהָב* used (Sarfatti 1982: 77). Note that *כָּהָם* occurs in LBH in Dan. 10.5, although its distribution hardly favours the idea that it is characteristic specifically of LBH (*contra* Dobbs-Allsopp 1998: 14).

3.3.1.20. *Theophoric element יְהוָה*-. Kutscher (1974: 4-5, 122-23) suggested that the use of the theophoric element *יְהוָה*—in personal names in the MT of Isaiah reflected a linguistic background in the pre-exilic period. In contrast, the use of the short form *יהו*—marked 1QIsa's linguistic background as from the Second Temple period. This idea is based on Torczyner's work on the Lachish letters where, it should be noted, he went to great lengths to explain away pre-exilic evidence of the co-existence of the short ending (Torczyner 1938: 24-25). While the long form certainly predominates in the inscriptions, I found the short form 14 times.¹⁷ No clear chronology emerges from the biblical evidence. Note especially the tendency of the LBH Chronicles to have long endings where the SBH Kings has short (Japhet 1968: 339).

3.3.1.21. *Use of the infinitive construct*. Polzin (1976: 45-46; cf. Wright 1998: 67-72) argues that LBH shows a less frequent use of the infinitive construct with *כִּ* and *כֵּן* (typically 'when'), and that even when LBH uses these they are found without introductory *וַיְהִי*. He further argues that LBH shows an increased use of the infinitive construct with *לְ* ('to'; Polzin 1976: 56-58). The Hebrew inscriptions present 19 forms identified as infinitive constructs with a preposition,¹⁸ 17 of them with *לְ* and only one

17. Gezer Calendar left margin and reverse; Tell Jemmeh ostrakon 2.3, 4; for the seals see Gogel 1998: 485, 486, 489, 490, 493; Deutsch and Heltzer 1995: 47.

18. With *לְ*: Arad 1.8; 24.18; 40.14; 111.7; Lachish 3.1-2, 10, 14, 15, 18, 20 (note the number in Lachish 3!); 6.6; 13.1; Mešad Ḥashavyahu 1.12-13; Moussaieff 1.2;

each with כ and כ. Neither of these latter two cases appears with ייִה. Gogel (1998: 289-90) notes that no example of ייִה appears in the inscriptions. Schüle (2000: 182-86) argues that this is evidence that ייִה is a late redactional element in BH. Instead, in the inscriptions circumstantial clauses have a prepositional/adverbial phrase in first position. Although the inscriptions link in with what might be expected of LBH in these cases, note for example that there are EBH cases of infinitives without ייִה (Polzin 1976: 46) and LBH cases with ייִה (Rooker 1990a: 103).

3.3.2. *Other Links with LBH.* In this section I present forms which have connections with LBH sources but for which linguistic oppositions with SBH have not been found.

3.3.2.1. וְלִקְרֹסִי ('and to the Qerosite')—Arad 18.5. The Qerosites are only attested, as a family of temple servants, in Ezra 2.44/Neh. 7.47.

3.3.2.2. יִקְרֶה אֵת ('something happen to')—Arad 24.16. The imperfect of קרה with אֵת as the object marker only occurs in Qoh. 2.14; 9.11. However, note the participle with אֵת in Gen. 42.29.

3.3.2.3. דְּבַר הַמֶּלֶךְ ('an order from the king')—Arad 24.17. The expression is very common in Chronicles and Esther, but for EBH note 1 Sam. 21.9.

3.3.2.4. סַמְדֵּר a type of wine(?) Hazor 7. This word is otherwise only attested in Song 2.13, 15; 7.13, meaning 'flower buds of the vine' (KB, II: 759).

3.3.2.5. לֹא בָנִים ('without sons')—Moussaieff Ostrakon 2.3. This expression is found only in 1 Chron. 2.30, 32 (Berlejung and Schüle 1998: 69), as well as Rabbinic sources and Aramaic (Qimron 1998: 181-82). However, the use of לֹא in similar syntagms to indicate non-existence or non-presence is attested in all strata of Hebrew, albeit only in poetry in BH outside of Chronicles (Van Peursen 1999: 226).

3.3.2.6. וְהָיָה יָדְךָ עִמִּי ('let your hand be with me')—Moussaieff Ostrakon 2.3-4. This expression is only found in 1 Chron. 4.10 (Berlejung and Schüle 1998: 70; cf. Qimron 1998: 184).

3.3.3. *Conclusion.* It is initially quite surprising to see how many links can be suggested between the inscriptions and LBH. One might have expected these to be rarer, or indeed non-existent, as has sometimes been claimed in the literature (cf. Albright 1939: 20-21; Ehrensverd 1997: 36-37). On

Ophel 1.3; Siloam Tunnel 2, 4. With כ: Kuntillet 'Ajrud 8.1 (Phoenician?). With כ: Arad 16.3.

reflection, however, this discovery can be seen in harmony with the biblical evidence. Scholars of LBH have always admitted that LBH forms could be found in EBH works. It is only the accumulation of such features which marks a work as LBH (see, e.g., Hurvitz 1973: 76).

LBH features are found occasionally in pre-exilic texts, a fact demonstrated by the inscriptions. Thus (at least some of) the features of LBH were in existence in this period (remember that very few LBH features are unattested in EBH sources). Occasionally these LBH forms made their way into SBH compositions. An issue which has received inadequate attention is the logical argument: if pre-exilic authors could occasionally choose to use LBH forms, why could a pre-exilic author not choose to write in a style with a heavy concentration of LBH features (cf. my argument regarding Qoheleth in I. Young 1993: 140-57)? If the LBH features existed in pre-exilic times, yet authors chose to avoid them, can we prove that post-exilic authors could not likewise have been able to avoid such forms and write SBH?

The accumulation of LBH forms discussed in this section do not, in my judgment, indicate a special relationship between the inscriptions and LBH. For one thing, too few 'LBH' forms are completely unattested in SBH sources. Also, one does not find a concentration of LBH features in one inscription comparable with the core LBH texts. In this sense the arguments of Hurvitz and Ehrensverd cited above are correct: the inscriptions are like SBH in that they avoid a heavy concentration of LBH features. However, this is not a strong argument that therefore SBH and the inscriptions must be closely related. Indeed, we did not find strong evidence of a special relationship between the inscriptions and SBH. Instead, the inscriptions share much that is common to both SBH and LBH. Occasionally they share special features of SBH and LBH. Quite a number of times inscriptional Hebrew is independent of both types of Hebrew (cf. I. Young 1997: 8-9). It is to these independent features that we now turn.

3.4. *Inscriptional Forms Unattested or Rare in the MT*

3.4.1. *Unattested in the MT.* Forms are unattested in the Bible for a number of reasons. Sometimes it is due to accident: no context for mentioning that word occurs in the Hebrew Bible. At other times other words are preferred in BH to express the meaning of the inscriptional word.

3.4.1.1. *Abbreviations.* The inscriptions use abbreviations such as ש for 'shekel' (e.g. Arad 16.5; see G.I. Davies 1991: 488) or ב for 'Bath (measure)' (e.g. Arad 1.3; see G.I. Davies 1991: 512-13). Although strongly suspected to have been used at some stage of the history of the text (Tov

1992: 256-58), no abbreviations are attested in existing biblical manuscripts.

3.4.1.2. נתן ('give!')—*Arad 1.2; 2.1; 7.2; 11.2*. Several scholars have suggested that this is the qal imperative of the root נתן, which in BH always drops the initial *nun* (Sarfatti 1982: 71; Gai 1996: 530-31) instead of an infinitive absolute used as a command (see 3.2.3).

3.4.1.3. יום ('day')—*Arad 1.4 etc.* The consistent defective spelling of this word in contrast to BH יום has been interpreted as indicating that the inscriptional form was pronounced *yām (Cross and Freedman 1952: 50, 53; Schüle 2000: 52), the unattested singular to the MT plural ימים ('days'). However, it cannot be excluded that we have merely a case of non-MT orthography (cf. below, section 4).

3.4.1.4. עוד ('remainder')—*Arad 1.5; 5.3*. The noun עוד ('remainder') is unattested in BH, which uses a range of other words for this meaning: נשאר, נותר, יתר, שאר (V. Sasson 1979: 17-26; cf. I. Young 1993: 113). Ahituv (1995: 379-80) notes the occurrence of עוד in MH. Sarfatti (1992: 60-61) argues that the use of עוד as a noun, rather than an adverb 'still, yet, again (etc.)', represents a typologically more ancient linguistic usage in the inscriptions as opposed to BH.

3.4.1.5. קמח הראשון ('the first flour')—*Arad 1.5-6; cf. 5.3-4*. Although various sorts of flour are mentioned in BH, this designation is not used.

3.4.1.6. תרכב ('you shall load[?']')—*Arad 1.6-7*. The interpretation of this word is disputed, but it is generally thought to be used in a sense not attested in the Bible, such as 'load onto a donkey' (Ahituv 1995: 380-81) or 'grind' (Gibson 1973: 52; V. Sasson 1979: 7-16; for other suggestions see Aharoni 1981: 13; Renz and Röllig 1995, I: 355-56; Schüle 2000: 115 n. 2).

3.4.1.7. שאל לשלמך ('may [the Lord] ask for your wellbeing')—*Arad 18.2-3*. In BH the corresponding phrase attaches the pronoun to an additional preposition ל, not onto the noun שלום (e.g. וישאלו להם לשלום, Gen. 43.27). Parallels to the Arad form are found in pre-Israelite Canaan in the Canaanite-Akkadian of the Ta'anach and Amarna letters (cf. *ilāni lišalu šulumka*, 'may the gods ask after your wellbeing', Ta'anach 1.5-6; Rainey 1971: 14-15; Loewenstamm 1972: 70). Gibson (1973: 53; cf. Loewenstamm 1972: 70) notes further that the expression is not used in the Bible with God as the subject. In Deut. 23.7 we find the expression לא תדרש שלמם ('you shall not seek their peace'), with the suffix on the noun, albeit with a different verbal root.

3.4.1.8. ברכתך ל—*Arad 16.2 etc.* The preposition ל used to express agency with the verb ברך is only attested in inscriptional Hebrew, at Arad, and Kuntillet 'Ajrud. The Sheffield Dictionary (*DCH*, II: 270) also cites 1 Chron. 29.20. However, here the ל seems to be simply indicating the object. Contrast, for example, Gen. 27.7: 'I will bless you before (לפני) the Lord'. Sarfatti notes, however, the use of the passive participle ... ל ברוך in, for instance, Judg. 17.2. The parallels to the inscription form in the Aramaic of the Hermopolis papyri from c. 500 BCE (Hermopolis 1.2 etc.; cf. Hoftijzer and Jongeling 1995, I: 201) show the dangers of using Aramaic sources to establish the chronology of Hebrew.

3.4.1.9. ולדבר ('And concerning the matter...')—*Arad 18.6-7*. For 'concerning', BH prefers constructions with other prepositions, particularly על (see, e.g., Gen. 43.18).

3.4.1.10. חיהוה ('as the Lord lives')—*Lachish 3.9; Arad 21.5(?)* (cf. Renz and Röllig 1995, I: 387; Gogel 1998: 391). BH always spells this expression as two words (cf. Lachish 6.12; 12.3). While we may just be dealing with a non-MT spelling (cf. section 4), it is likely that the spelling reflects a colloquial pronunciation of the idiom (cf. Schniedewind 2000: 160-61). Rooker cites this form as evidence of the SBH morphology of the perfect of the verb חיה (Rooker 1990a: 82 n. 55). However the expression is not normally considered to contain a verb (BDB: 311-12; KB, I: 307-308).

3.4.1.11. בנבשכם ויהבקידים ('and hand them over')—*Arad 24.14-15; בנבשכם ('on your life')—Arad 24.18*. The פ/ב interchange in these words (בקר for BH נבש and נבש for BH נפש) has received much discussion (cf. Sarfatti 1982: 69-71; 1992: 43-44; I. Young 1993: 112-13). Whatever the explanation, we clearly have two non-biblical forms here.

3.4.1.12. ים [י]רד ('[before] the sun sets')—*Arad 40.10-11*. The reading and interpretation of this section present some difficulties (cf. Renz and Röllig 1995, I: 148) but most commentators read as above. The only possible biblical parallel where the day 'goes down' (ירד) rather than 'enters' (בוא) is found in Judg. 19.11, which is, however, a very difficult text (cf. BDB: 433).

3.4.1.13. איננו יכלם לשלח ('we are not able to send')—*Arad 40.13-14*. The participle of יכל is not attested in BH, but is typical of MH (Pérez Fernández 1999: 114). Similarly, the negation of the participle by אין is typical of MH (Segal 1927: 162-63). Eskhult (2000: 88) notes the parallel verses 1 Kgs 22.8//2 Chron. 18.7 where Kings has לא + imperfect,

whereas the LBH Chronicles has יין + participle. In BH we would normally expect לֵא נֹכֵחַ instead of the Arad form (Aharoni 1981: 73; cf. Sarfatti 1992: 55-56). If one wished to equate MH with 'lateness', this form would thus qualify as LBH.

3.4.1.14. יין כחל ('dark wine'¹⁹)—*Avigad Wine Decanter 1*. Although many sorts of wine are referred to in the Hebrew Bible (Jordan 2002), this variety is not mentioned. This is either by accident or because BH refers to this sort of wine using a different name. Rabbinic sources refer to dark wine using the adjective שחור (Demskey 1972: 234).

3.4.1.15. סרט ('write[?]')—*City of David 2.1* (Naveh 2000: 2-3). The root סרט is not attested in the Hebrew Bible. Naveh (2000: 3) wonders whether 'it stands for שרט (> סרט in later Hebrew), meaning "to incise, to scratch, to make marks, to make incisions in the body, to wound"'.

3.4.1.16. ירחו ('months[?]')—*Gezer Calendar 1* (twice), 2, 6. If this form is to be understood as terminating in a masculine plural construct case ending (I. Young 1992b: 363-66), rather than a proleptic suffix (see 3.3.1.6), it represents a form unattested in the Bible.

3.4.1.17. עצר ('harvesting[?] [flax]')—*Gezer Calendar 3*. Although the tool named מַעצָר is attested in the Hebrew Bible (KB, II: 615) the verb is unattested. Since the exact translation is uncertain we cannot be sure whether there is a linguistic opposition to a biblical word such as קצר ('harvest').

3.4.1.18. קץ ('summer fruit')—*Gezer Calendar 7*. BH only attests the form קִיץ. The absence of the medial *yod* has suggested to scholars that the Gezer form had a reduced diphthong (*qēṣ*), contrary to the biblical evidence (Gibson 1973: 4). It is possible, however, that we merely have here an orthographic difference (cf. section 4).

3.4.1.19. גדר ('walled plot[?]')—*Gibeon 1* etc. BH only attests the sense 'wall', whereas some scholars take this word in the inscriptions to refer to a walled plot or a vineyard (Gogel 1998: 315; cf. *DCH*, II: 327). However, other scholars see the form as a proper noun (Gibson 1973: 56).

3.4.1.20. *Hieratic numerals*. Our biblical texts spell numbers in full. This is found in some inscriptions (e.g. the 'year 9' and 'year 10' Samaria ostraca), but not in others (e.g. the 'year 15' Samaria ostraca, or commonly

in the Arad ostraca), where hieratic numerals of Egyptian origin are used (see Millard 1995).

3.4.1.21. מפלקם ('dividers[?]')—*Horvat 'Uza Jar 8* (Beit-Arieh 1993: 34-40). The root פלק is not attested in BH. Beit-Arieh suggests a connection with the root פלג ('divide'), and hence a פ/ק interchange (Beit-Arieh 1993: 38).

3.4.1.22. חדר ('tomb chamber')—*Khirbet el-Qom 1; Siloam Tomb 2*. BH attests the sense of 'inner room'. The reference to a tomb chamber is only attested in the inscriptions (*DCH*, III: 163-64).

3.4.1.23. מצרייה ('from his enemies')—*Khirbet el-Qom 3.3*. The suffix ייה ('his') is possibly related to the suffix attested in Hab. 3.10 יְיָהוּ and Job 24.23 יְיָהוּ (see Gogel 1998: 157-58 n. 182).

3.4.1.24. *Divine element יי*—*Kuntillet 'Ajrud; Samaria Ostraca* etc. BH employs the divine elements יהו and יה at the end of names, whereas inscriptions relating both to the Northern Kingdom and the Southern Kingdom (I. Young 1993: 114-15) have a form without the *he*, namely, יי. In general the יי- names are northern, whereas most southern names agree with the biblical יהו/יה- (see 3.3.1.20). Nevertheless, despite hints of a different situation (Diringer and Brock 1968: 41; Briquel-Chatonnet 1992: 104-105) it is significant that our current texts do not mention northerners with the יי- theophoric element.

3.4.1.25. יבכר ('may he give first knowledge')—*Lachish 2.5*. This sense is unattested in BH (cf. Emerton 2001: 12).

3.4.1.26. לנצח ('ever')—*Lachish 3.10*. The expression לנצח is never used in BH with reference to past time (Torczyner 1938: 17, 56; Gibson 1973: 40).

3.4.1.27. עת כים ('even today')—*Lachish 2.3; 4.1; 5.5; 8.2*. This collocation is unattested in BH.

3.4.1.28. בתסבת ('in the turning of')—*Lachish 4.9*. This noun is unattested in BH. Its specific nuance is debated; one suggestion is 'inspection tour' (cf. V. Sasson 1979: 27-36; 1982a; Renz and Röllig 1995, I: 422).

3.4.1.29. יין עשן ('strong wine')—*Lachish 25.1*. This designation for wine is unattested in BH.

3.4.1.30. מוז ('extract')—*Lachish 30.1*. Lemaire (1980: 92-93) suggests that this is a designation of a type of wine, unattested in the Hebrew Bible, and suggests reading it in a Hazor inscription also (Hazor 7; cf. Renz and Röllig 1995, I: 128).

3.4.1.31. צמקם שחרת ('black raisins')—*Lachish 30.1*. In BH, 'raisins' are masculine (1 Sam. 30.12); whereas here the adjective indicates them to be feminine (Lemaire 1980: 94).

19. Since all wine in this period was probably red (Jordan 2002), the precise sense of 'dark wine' is questionable. Demsky's references might suggest a darker variety of red wine (Demsky 1972: 234), whereas Avigad suggested that the wine was not named after a characteristic but was named after a locality כחל (Avigad 1972: 4-5). In both cases we are still talking about the name of a variety of wine.

3.4.1.32. וָאִסָּם ('and stored')—*Mešad Hashavyahu* 1.5, 6-7. As pointed out above (3.3.1.10) the noun 'storehouse' is rare in BH. The verb is unattested. BH uses other words for 'storing', for example, אָצַר (V. Sasson 1979: 46-55).

3.4.1.33. כִּימָם ('according to the agreed days[?]')—*Mešad Hashavyahu* 1.5, 7. Whether understood as כִּימָם ('as usual') or כִּי־יָמָם ('as every day'; cf. Renz and Röllig 1995, I: 325), the nuance is not attested in BH.

3.4.1.34. יֵעֲנוּ לִי ('they will testify for me')—*Mešad Hashavyahu* 1.10, 11. BH only attests עָנָה ב־ ('testify against').

3.4.1.35. שְׁלַח אֶת שְׁלָמֶךָ ('I have sent peace')—*papMurabba* 'at 17a.1. The greeting 'send peace' is not attested in BH. Normally one asks (שְׁאַל) about the wellbeing (לְשָׁלוֹם) of someone. Sarfatti (1982: 80) notes that the related expression at Arad (16.1-2; 21.1-2; 40.2-3), שְׁלַח לְשָׁלוֹם, is also not attested in BH. He notes an occurrence of שְׁלַח שְׁלָמֶךָ at Elephantine (CAP 41.3), which is another example of the difficulties of guessing what is in contemporary Hebrew on the basis of Aramaic sources.

3.4.1.36. נָהַל ('guide')—*Neriyahu Seal* (Deutsch and Heltzer 1994: 54-55). The verbal root נָהַל (piel) is 'to guide' and is well known in BH; but the noun is unattested. However, since it is hard to think of a BH equivalent (there is no noun form of נָהַל ['lead'] attested either) this is probably chance.

3.4.1.37. נִצָּץ *weights*. The weight name נִצָּץ is not mentioned in the Hebrew Bible. Other weight names such as כֶּקֶע and פִּים are also poorly attested, so this may simply be chance (Diringer and Brock 1968: 40; Scott 1970).

3.4.1.38. שָׁנָה ('year')—*Samaria Ostraca* 1.1 etc. Even in texts which might be considered to have links with the Northern Kingdom, for example, narratives about northern kings, or the prophecy of Amos, the word for year is שָׁנָה, construct שָׁנָה. The word 'year' is not attested in southern inscriptions.

3.4.1.39. יָי ('wine')—*Samaria Ostraca* 5.3 etc. The spelling without the medial *yod* has suggested to scholars that the word was pronounced with a reduced diphthong (Cross and Freedman 1952: 49). Southern Hebrew attests יָי (e.g. Arad 1.3), which links up with BH יָי. However, note that the form יָי is found even in parts of the Bible where a northern link might be expected, such as narratives dealing with northerners, or the prophets Hosea and Amos. It is, of course, possible that the difference is merely one of spelling, rather than pronunciation (cf. section 4).

3.4.1.40. יָי שֵׁן ('old wine')—*Samaria Ostraca* 5.3 etc. This designation of wine is never found in the Bible, but is attested in MH (Sarfatti 1982: 76).

3.4.1.41. שֶׁמֶן רַחֵץ ('purified oil')—*Samaria Ostraca* 16.3 etc. The term seems to be parallel to various BH (and southern?) words describing oil, such as זָךְ ('clear, pure'; V. Sasson 1979: 65-75; 1981; Ahituv 1992: 176), but note the alternative translation: 'oil for washing' (cf. Renz and Röllig 1995, I: 83).

3.4.1.42. נִקְבָּה ('tunnel')—*Siloam Tunnel* 1. V. Sasson (1982b: 116; cf. 1979: 105) contrasts this noun with BH תַּעֲלָה. Other scholars suggest reading a verbal form (Renz and Röllig 1995, I: 183-84). Note that the verb נִקַּב is never used in BH referring to anything but a small hole (V. Sasson 1979: 99; 1982b: 114).

3.4.1.43. וְזָה הִיא דְּבַר הָ—*Siloam Tunnel* 1. As discussed above (3.2.18), the parallel BH expressions all lack הִיא.

3.4.1.44. זָרַח ('fissure[?]')—*Siloam Tunnel* 3. This word is unattested in BH, although its exact meaning is debated (Renz and Röllig 1995, I: 184-85).

3.4.1.45. לִקְרַת ('towards')—*Siloam Tunnel* 4. BH always derives this construction from the root לָקַח. The Siloam form seems to be from the parallel root קָרַח (Renz and Röllig 1995, I: 188), unless the *aleph* has been dropped (cf. Gibson 1973: 23; Gogel 1998: 211 n. 274).

3.4.1.46. בְּמֵאתָיִם ('for [one thousand] 200')—*Siloam Tunnel* 5. Gibson (1973: 23) notes regarding the initial preposition: 'There are no very clear parallels to the use of [b]...'.

3.4.1.47. אָרֹר הָאָדָם אֲשֶׁר ('cursed be the man [one] who...')—*Silwan Tomb* 2.2. Sarfatti (1992: 58-60; cf. 1982: 74-75) points out the contrast between this expression and the common biblical expression אָרֹר הָאִישׁ. He notes that this is related to a more general phenomenon. BH rarely uses אָדָם as an indefinite pronoun, 'someone, anyone', preferring instead to use the other word for 'man', אִישׁ. He notes that MH, in contrast, uses only אָדָם for this function. Further, Sarfatti notes the use of אָדָם in the inscriptions as an indefinite pronoun in Lachish 4.5-6, אִין שָׁם אָדָם ('there is no-one there')—contrast 2 Kgs 7.10: אִין שָׁם אִישׁ, although אָדָם is also used in the context. His third example, from Lachish 3.4-5 rests on a dubious reading (cf. Renz and Röllig 1995, I: 417). Sarfatti notes that the more common BH usage of אִישׁ as an indefinite pronoun also occurs in the inscriptions from Arad (40.8) and Lachish (3.9-10), and three times in the expression 'a man to his fellow' in the Siloam Tunnel inscription. With a small corpus one cannot meaningfully talk about the relative

proportions of אָרָם vs. שָׁא in the inscriptions vs. BH, but the contrast in the specific case of the curse expression is instructive.

3.4.1.48. *Theophoric element* יָהוּ. D. Talshir (1998) demonstrates systematic differences between the epigraphic evidence and the MT in the question of the theophoric prefixes –יָהוּ and –יָהוּ. Thus, for example, the name יוֹאָב ('Joab') is found 146 times in the Bible with no trace of יָהוּאָב. The long form, however, is the one which prevails in the epigraphic evidence (D. Talshir 1998: 368 n. 19).

3.4.2. Rare Forms in the MT

3.4.2.1. עַתָּה ('now')—*Arad 1.2 etc.* The MT normally attests the long form עַתָּה. However, the form without the *he* is attested as the *kethib* in Ezek. 23.43 and Ps. 74.6. The inscriptional form either reflects a linguistic variation (Cross and Freedman 1952: 52-53; Andersen 1999: 9-10) or simply a variation of spelling practice (cf. section 4 below).

3.4.2.2. עֲבַר ('produce')—*Arad 31.10*. The word עֲבַר only appears in Josh. 5.11-12, where it appears with (is explained by?) the more common word תְּבוּאָה (Aharoni 1981: 58).

3.4.2.3. סַחֲבַת ('rags[?']')—*City of David 2.1 (Naveh 2000: 2-3)*. The word סַחֲבַת is only attested in Jer. 38.11-12.

3.4.2.4. כָּל ('measuring')—*Gezer 5; Mešad Hashavyahu 1.5, 6, 8*. The qal verb כֹּלֵל ('measure') is found in BH only at Isa. 40.12 (Diringer and Brock 1968: 41-42). A derivation from כָּלָה ('finish') is less likely (cf. V. Sasson 1979: 56-64; Renz and Röllig 1995, I: 325-26). The general BH word for 'measuring' is מִדָּה.

3.4.2.5. בִּרְכָה ('I blessed')—*Kuntillet 'Ajrud 1; כלת ('I measured')—Mešad Hashavyahu 1.8; שלחת ('I sent')—papMurabba'at 17a.1*. The first person perfect without a final *yod* is attested five times in the MT (GKC: 44i). The inscription forms may be interpreted as either a variant short form of the suffix (Gibson 1973: 30; Andersen 1999: 10) or as simply a spelling variation (cf. below section 4).

3.4.2.6. אֲשֶׁרָה ('his Asherah')—*Kuntillet 'Ajrud 8.2 etc.* It is debatable whether any examples of suffixes on proper nouns appear in BH. However, it is also possible that the word 'asherah' here is the designation for an object, not a personal name (e.g. Emerton 1999a).

3.4.2.7. אֵין ('there is not')—*Lachish 2.5-6*. Gibson (1973: 37-38) suggests reading the negative אֵין in this place, which only occurs in Job 22.30 in the MT. It is common in RH. However, more commonly scholars suggest two letters are missing, giving the reading אֵיןִי ('my lord')—Renz and Röllig 1995, I: 412.

3.4.2.8. אֶתְנַנְהוּ ('I would give him[?']')—*Lachish 3.12*. All of the various suggested interpretations involve forms rare or unattested in BH. As נתן ('give') the suffix with extra *nun* is rare and poetic in BH. The verb תִּנְה ('repeat') is a rare dialect form of SBH שָׁנָה. The verb תָּנָה ('pay') is unattested in BH (cf. I. Young 1998a: 412 n. 10; Schniedewind 2000: 161).

3.4.2.9. נַחְנוּ ('we')—*Lachish 4.10-11*. This form occurs four times in the MT Pentateuch (Gen. 42.11; Exod. 16.7, 8; Num. 32.32, all in quoted speech) and once in Lamentations (Lam. 3.42, in an acrostic). The Samaritan Pentateuch has the standard form נַחְנִי throughout (Tal 1994). נַחְנוּ is the only 1st c. pl. independent pronoun attested in the inscriptions (Gogel 1998: 154). On the basis of its distribution, Dobbs-Allsopp (1998: 24-25) argues that it is an 'early' linguistic feature. However, it is hardly characteristic of SBH, but rather a minority form. It is to be noted that the inscriptional form is considered typologically older than the regular BH form (Dobbs-Allsopp 1998: 24).

3.4.2.10. בַּעַת הַזֶּה ('in this season')—*Lachish 6.2*. As pointed out above (3.3.1.8) עַתָּה is normally feminine in BH. LBH attests the masculine plural עַתִּים, and עַתָּה as singular masculine is very rarely attested in the MT.

3.4.2.11. חֲמֹר ('wine')—*Rās ez-Zētūn 1*. The word חֲמֹר ('wine') is rare in BH (Deut. 32.14 cf. Isa. 27.2). It is possible, however, that this inscription is Phoenician (Renz and Röllig 1995, I: 37).

3.4.2.12. רֵעִי ('his fellow')—*Siloam Tunnel 2, 3, 4*. BH attests 'his fellow' as רֵעִי 117 times, and only once as רֵעִי (Jer. 6.21). Most likely underlying the Siloam form is a quite different morphology than is represented in the Tiberian Hebrew vocalization of Jer. 6.21 (e.g. *rē'ēw*: Renz and Röllig 1995, I: 187; cf. below with n. 20). Alternatively, one could simply take the suffix as plural (Schüle 2000: 37), bringing it in line with normal orthographic practice in the inscriptions. In this case, we would have a contrast to the regular use of the singular in the equivalent biblical phrase.

3.4.2.13. הִיא ('she was')—*Siloam Tunnel 3*. It is generally assumed that the 3rd fem. sg. perfect of III-*he* (לָהּ) verbs developed *hayāt* > *hāyā* with an additional feminine suffix (Z.S. Harris 1939: 75-76). Traces of the older ending are found in BH (e.g. Lev. 25.21; cf. 2 Kgs 9.37 [GKC: 75m]), and it is common in MH (Sarfatti 1992: 64-65). This makes it more likely that we have a variant morphology from SBH than that the difference is merely a question of orthography. The Siloam form is the only 3rd fem. sg. perfect in the inscriptions (Gogel 1998: 89-90). Harris considered the form as evidence that the language of the inscriptions represented an older type of Hebrew than that eventually fixed in the biblical text (Z.S. Harris 1939: 76).

3.4.3. *Conclusion.* There is a significant amount of variation from BH in the inscriptions. Most important are the numerous cases discussed where the inscriptions use forms of language which contrast with what is attested or regular in BH.

The non-biblical forms, coupled with the links with LBH, call into question an easy equation of inscriptional Hebrew with SBH. There are undeniably cases where the inscriptions link with SBH, against LBH, for instance. However, these were found to be uncommon, making the case for a special link between the inscriptions and SBH appear quite weak.

Inscriptional Hebrew is best seen as an independent corpus within ancient Hebrew, rather than as a mere adjunct of SBH. As an independent corpus it has links sometimes with SBH, sometimes with LBH, and sometimes with other types of Hebrew such as ABH (I. Young 1992b) and MH (Sarfatti 1992). Sometimes it displays forms independent of all of them. In my judgment the links with SBH are closer than with LBH or the others. However, the links are not strong enough to posit an identity, chronological or otherwise, between SBH and the inscriptions.

4. Orthography

SBH—indeed, every Bible text in our possession—shows a systematic difference from the Hebrew inscriptions in orthography. This is in two main categories. First, the 3rd masc. sg. pronominal suffixes. Second, the extent of use of medial *matres lectionis*. A third category would include the other anomalies above which I noted could be explained as spelling variations rather than, say, morphological variations (e.g. עת for עתה, ['now'] in 3.4.2.1, or י' ['day'] in 3.4.1.3).

The 3rd masc. sg. suffix on a singular noun is ך in the inscriptions. With the exception of some 55 cases (see I. Young 2001c), in our biblical manuscripts it is ך. No clear case of ך in the inscriptions is attested. The one possible candidate רעו in the Siloam Tunnel is anomalous and is at present best explained on other grounds.²⁰

20. Several proposals are discussed by Gogel 1998: 156-57 n. 181. In addition note the attractive suggestion of Andersen and Forbes who note that there is evidence that the retention of the original III-*yod* (י') can lead to the attachment to the singular of suffixes more typical of plural nouns, hence רעו (Andersen and Forbes 1986: 41). On this phenomenon see GKC: 273-74 §93ss. Alternatively, a straightforward reading of the form as plural solves the orthographic problem (see 3.4.2.12).

The 3rd masc. sg. suffix on plural nouns is -w (ו) in the inscriptions. With, again, a significant minority of exceptions, in our biblical texts the form is ך. The only possible example of the latter form in the inscriptions, פני in Ketef Hinnom Amulet 2.9, is problematic.²¹

Even granting all the possible exceptions, a clear contrast in the spelling of these suffixes emerges between the inscriptional corpus and the biblical manuscripts. The contrast has usually been explained as a historical development. The older spelling is that of the inscriptions. At some stage before our first attested biblical manuscripts in the third century BCE, probably in the Persian period, a thorough spelling reform was undertaken. The exceptional forms in our biblical manuscripts are the remnants of the older spelling of the biblical texts. It is clear from many examples that ancient scribes were capable of leaving such remnants.²²

A discernable process in the inscriptions is the growth in the use of *waw* and *yod* to mark vowels in the middle of words. Thus ארוך in Siloam Tomb 1. 2 stands for the qal passive participle 'cursed' (ארוך in the MT). Nevertheless, it is clear that these *matres lectionis* are not used with the same frequency as in our biblical manuscripts, even in the latest dated inscriptions. Thus, for example, while the word 'prophet' in the MT is always נביא (167 times) with a *yod*, Lachish 3.20, from the last days of the monarchy, spells the word נבא. In this feature also, therefore, the orthography of our Bibles is of a type later than that of the inscriptions.

5. Concluding Remarks

The generally close link between the language of the Bible and that of the inscriptions shows that it is plausible that something similar to SBH was the language of the monarchic period. The inscriptional evidence is not drastically inconsistent with a pre-exilic origin of those biblical books whose contents suggest such a dating.

The link with the inscriptions does not, however, prove that SBH could not have been written in the post-exilic period. Haggai and Zechariah, which date themselves to the early post-exilic period, are considered to contain few, if any, traces of LBH (see Ehrensverd's contribution to the

21. Several proposals are discussed by Gogel 1998: 159-60 n. 188. The texts are dated to the third century BCE by Renz and Rölliig 1995, I: 447-56.

22. See, e.g., the comments of I. Young 1998b: 82 with n. 38. For a study of the distribution of the ך suffix and other theories about their significance see I. Young 2001c.

present volume). We have no other direct extra-biblical evidence of Hebrew before the third century BCE. We cannot deny the possibility that a form of language linked to the pre-exilic inscriptions continued in the post-exilic period. The fact that LBH features co-existed with SBH is already acknowledged in that the language of Ezekiel, dated earlier than, for example, Haggai and Zechariah, has many LBH features. The only question is how long the two styles co-existed.

The language of the inscriptions is not identical with SBH. Instead, the language of the inscriptions must first of all be seen as independent of other types of BH, with links to all of them. The identity of SBH with inscriptional Hebrew cannot be taken for granted and used as a secure base on which to argue to conclusions about the nature and date of SBH.

The orthography of all known biblical manuscripts would seem to indicate that no manuscript in our possession could possibly date back unchanged earlier than the Persian period. We should not, of course, dogmatically assert that the inscriptions give us the full range of possible early Hebrews. Nevertheless, the best reading of the evidence at hand would place the Bible in its current form no earlier than the Persian period.

One need not conclude that the biblical texts were composed in the Persian period. However, the commonly assumed alternative scenario, that pre-Persian period texts were edited to change their orthography in the Persian period, raises important questions. Did scribal intervention merely limit itself to spelling? Or was there more widespread editing of the language? The vastly different editions of biblical books which were produced by scribal reworking (Ulrich 1999: *passim*) raise the likelihood that all features of the biblical text were subject to extensive editorial revision during the Second Temple period (cf. Knauf 1990: 22). The language of the pre-exilic inscriptions is close enough to that of BH to suggest that it is unnecessary and unlikely that the fundamental linguistic structure of pre-exilic compositions would have been altered. There is a stable core to BH in all its forms, what I have referred to as 'Common Hebrew'. However, in the study of LBH it is often the details that make all the difference, such as whether מן ('from') is attached to or separate from a following noun without the definite article (cf. Polzin 1976: 66). These are the very details which are found to change in scribal transmission (I. Young 2001b: 122-23).

In this connection it is interesting that the few distinctive linguistic forms we know from northern inscriptions, in particular שנה ('year') and the theophoric ending of names יי- , do not appear in the Hebrew biblical

texts in our possession. If northern sources lie behind say, the accounts of the kings of Israel or the words of the prophet Hosea, this may indicate that the distinctive features of the language have been radically altered during their transmission. Such a radical treatment of the language would raise doubts about our ability to discern northern dialect features in the current biblical texts, such as have been suggested by, among others, Rendsburg (1990b etc.), Wright (1998), and I. Young (1993).

The Hebrew inscriptions may thus be used in quite different reconstructions of the history of the Hebrew language. A strictly linear reading of the evidence discussed above might lead to a Persian period dating for BH. However, one should hesitate to draw far reaching conclusions on the basis of such meagre evidence.

Biblical Hebrew

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ABBREVIATIONS

1. Bibliographical Abbreviations

AB	Anchor Bible
ABD	David Noel Freedman (ed.), <i>The Anchor Bible Dictionary</i> (New York: Doubleday, 1992)
<i>AbrN</i>	<i>Abr-Nahrain</i>
<i>AbrNSup</i>	<i>Abr-Nahrain</i> , Supplements
<i>AcOr</i>	<i>Acta orientalia</i>
<i>AJBA</i>	<i>Australian Journal of Biblical Archaeology</i>
<i>AJSL</i>	<i>American Journal of Semitic Languages and Literatures</i>
ALASP	Abhandlungen zur Literatur Alt-Syrien-Palästinas
AnBib	Analecta biblica
ANES	<i>Ancient Near Eastern Studies</i>
AnOr	Analecta orientalia
AOAT	Alter Orient und Altes Testament
AOS	American Oriental Series
BASOR	<i>Bulletin of the American Schools of Oriental Research</i>
BBB	Bonner biblische Beiträge
BDB	Francis Brown, S.R. Driver and Charles A. Briggs, <i>A Hebrew and English Lexicon of the Old Testament</i> (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1907)
BETL	Bibliotheca ephemeridum theologicarum lovaniensium
BHS	<i>Biblia hebraica stuttgartensia</i>
<i>Bib</i>	<i>Biblica</i>
<i>BibInt</i>	<i>Biblical Interpretation: A Journal of Contemporary Approaches</i>
BibOr	Biblica et orientalia
BKAT	Biblischer Kommentar: Altes Testament
BIOSCS	<i>Bulletin of the International Organization for Septuagint and Cognate Studies</i>
BO	<i>Bibliotheca orientalis</i>
BR	<i>Bible Review</i>
BSOAS	<i>Bulletin of the School of Oriental and African Studies</i>
BZAW	Beihefte zur ZAW
CAD	<i>The Assyrian Dictionary of the Oriental Institute of the University of Chicago</i> (Chicago: The Institute, 1956–)

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